

What else to watch: *In Which We Serve* (1942) ■ *The Cruel Sea* (1953) ■ *Above Us the Waves* (1955) ■ *The Enemy Below* (1957) ■ *Sink the Bismarck!* (1960) ■ *The Hunt for Red October* (1990) ■ *Crimson Tide* (1995) ■ *Lebanon* (2009)

Nerves become strained as the mechanics desperately try to figure out a way of refloating the U-boat before it becomes crushed by depth pressure.

made war thrilling. Not all critics agreed with Buchheim. Audiences came out of the movie drained physically and emotionally. Petersen's movie does not depend on thrilling action sequences, though there are those. Rather, it oscillates between tense moments of danger and the tedium of weeks of fruitless hunting, in which the relationships between crew members becomes fraught. The movie's grip is in its psychology rather than in its action sequences. As its tagline said, it is "A journey to the edge of the mind."

Putting us in the boat

Das Boot's power stems from the director's determination to attain realism. He makes viewers understand what it was like to be in a wartime submarine, attempting desperate repairs, running out of oxygen and time. The movie was shot almost entirely



inside a real U-boat (on dry land), which could be tilted to 45 degrees to simulate a sudden dive. Two techniques contribute to the heightened realism. The first is an innovative use of sound. When destroyers are circling above the U-boat, all we hear in the silence are the sonar pings ringing off the hull, or the ferrous groaning and

popping of rivets as the boat dives to a dangerously low depth. Second is the cinematography of Jost Vacano. Despite the cramped space, Vacano used a handheld camera to create a sense of intimacy, training himself to run through narrow spaces and over bulkheads. The effect he created has influenced a whole generation of movies. ■



Wolfgang Petersen Director

Wolfgang Petersen is Germany's leading director of action movies. Born in Emden, Germany, in 1941, he studied theater in Berlin and Hamburg, before enrolling in the Berlin Film and Television Academy, after which he was making movies for television. In 1974, he directed his first feature, the thriller *One of the Other of Us*, and then in 1977 the controversial *Die Konsequenz*, a movie about gay love. But he made his name with *Das Boot*, which gave him

the prestige to direct Hollywood thrillers such as *In the Line of Fire* with Clint Eastwood, *Outbreak* (1995) with Dustin Hoffman, and the hugely popular *Air Force One* with Harrison Ford, Gary Oldman, and Glenn Close.

Key movies

1981 *Das Boot*
1993 *In the Line of Fire*
1997 *Air Force One*